
Navigating Institutional Archives of Suisse Romande Architecture Competitions

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Abstract

This project analyses large-scale corpora of architecture competitions in *Suisse Romande* using historical networks as its framework. A central part of Helvetic identity, competitions offer a rich survey of the relationships that make up Switzerland’s architectural history. We applied quantitative methods to restructure the well-respected *Archives de la Construction Moderne* (ACM) at EPFL into a network and framed our results using secondary literature and in-depth case studies. Echoing current scholarly attention (Frommel and Dufieux 2025), our contribution captures the ecosystem of competitions in French speaking Switzerland (*Suisse Romande*) is, as it crystallises in the late-19th and 20th centuries and assumes the importance it has now. Our methodology offers a novel way to view the contributions and importance of different actors in the competition scene that goes beyond the traditional canon.

Our project begins by performing a full analysis of the existing dataset and reflecting on the present bias and errors. This data was processed by Pierre Frey into a CSV and detailed in a collection of essays using basic metrics such as term frequency (Frey et al. 1995). We build off this early research by constructing two mirroring graphs: a *competitions graph* which consists of nodes representing individual competitions, which are connected by edges with weight indicating the number of co-occurring architects; and an *architects graph*, which uses competitors as its nodes and competition co-occurrence as its edges. We then use natural language processing to saturate these temporal/spatial networks with metadata such as location or topic clusters.

After having constructed our graphs out of over 4,000 competitors over nearly 800 competitions through over 100 years of history, we then operationalised key metrics such as PageRank, weighted degree, and greedy clustering (Langville and Meyer 2003; Brin and Page 1998). These metrics allowed us to identify previously unresearched but influential actors. They also allowed us to develop the concept of *potential architecture*, and place historical emphasis on the unbuilt (Chupin et al. 2002). The construction of historical networks provides a framework to define what constitutes a main actor in the history of *Suisse Romande* public architecture competitions.

These networks offer a conglomerate of projects, ideas, friends, rivals, and experiences: architects. Is it these figures who have landscaped *Suisse Romande* competitions? In his own analysis of his dataset, Pierre Frey adopted a frequentist conception of main actor. More competitions? More importance. The dice fell in Alphonse Laverrière’s favor, and he became

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the protagonist of Frey's writings. We chose a different, but parallel route: which architect is the most central in the network of co-occurrences? PageRank supplants and disguises frequency counts and reveals another kind of violent lattice to overlay onto the landscape. Our results and interpretation point to other, lesser-known ambitious men - Fonso Boschetti, Rodolphe Luscher, Jean Béguin, or Paul Morisod - who nonetheless build a more complete image of the Swiss architectural landscape.

References

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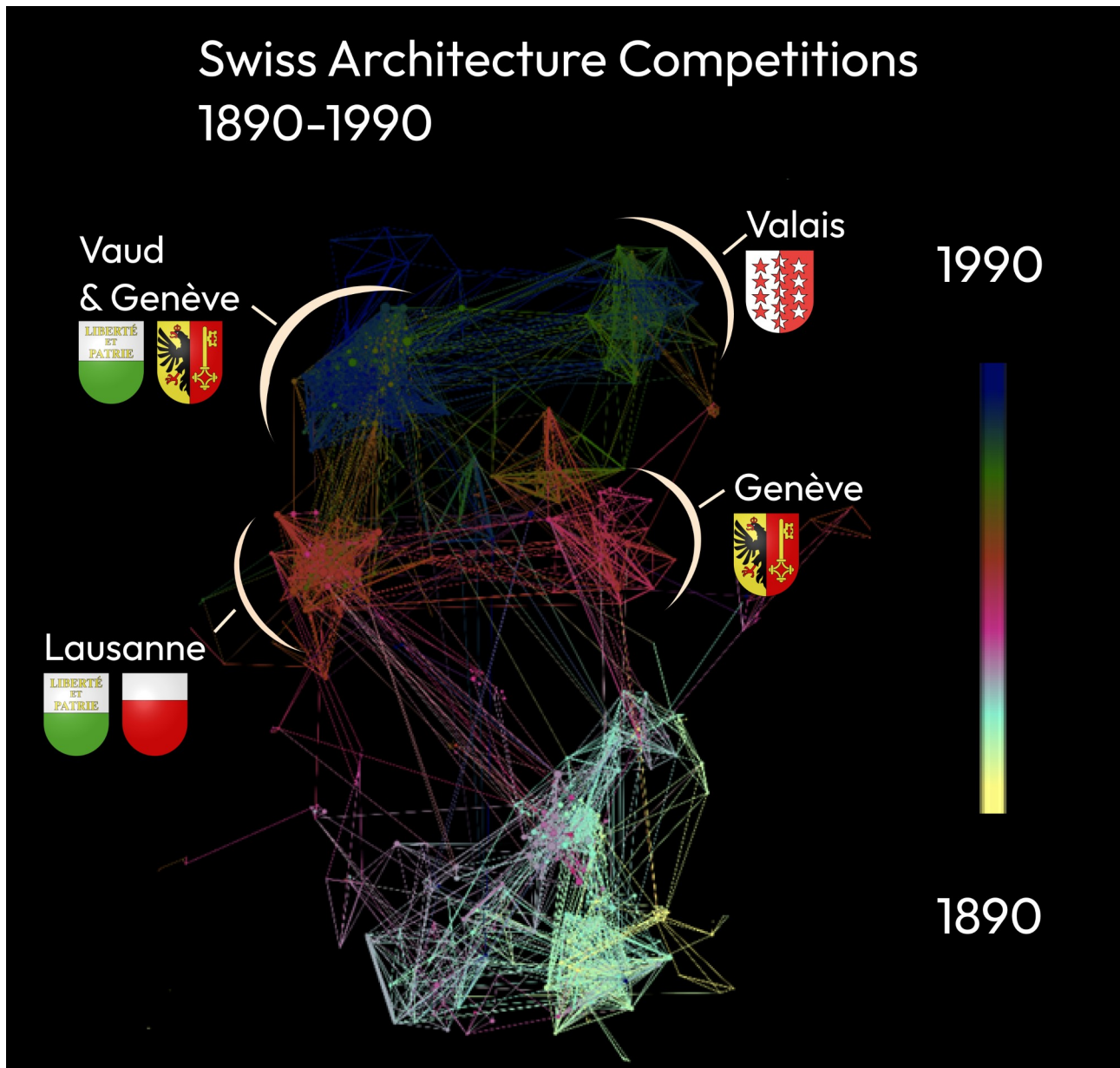


Figure 1. The competitions graph, constructed by competitor co-occurrence. $N = 795$, $E = 11,021$.

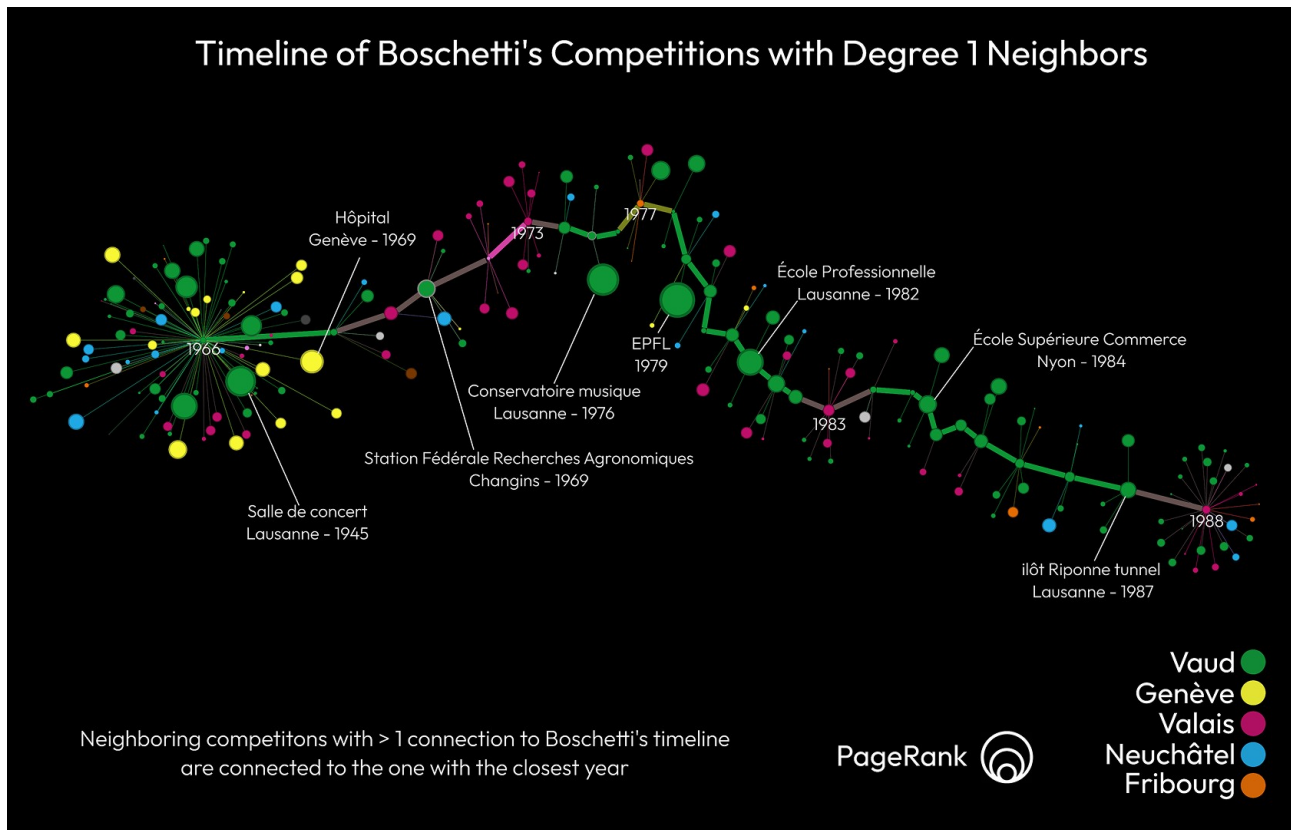


Figure 2. An individual actor's (Fonso Boschetti's) sub-network extracted from the two networks. Nodes represent individual competitions. Each competition's immediate neighbours are also displayed. Colors indicate location of competition, while size of the node indicates PageRank. This is an example of the interpretative and pedagogical tools that can be extracted from our networks.